roar in the middle of a performance. Dancers have to stop in the middle of their routines to bow because the applause drowns the orchestra. Bouquets are thrown left and right to the favorite dancer of the moment, and when fans disagree, they come to blows."[37]

As in the case of sport, access to ballet training was universalized, and children with talent were recruited into special schools for advanced training. Also like sport, Cuban ballet soared into the international scene.

Political Culture

Cuban intellectuals have been involved in a lively debate, especially since the 1990s, about the nature and meaning of democracy. While calling for a deepening and expansion of democracy in their country, they are careful to distinguish their own from U.S. conceptions of formal democracy.

Two Cuban scholars explain that "the construction of democracy in Cuba is not an exercise in constitutional engineering … but an all-encompassing project of social justice, development, national independence, and participatory opening."[38] Another Cuban academic explains: "elections are not synonymous with democracy but represent only one aspect of democracy. The West has tried for decades to reduce democracy to the exercise of voting every four years. To me, democracy is the daily input of the population on matters that affect their lives and not simply the casting of a ballot for a menu of candidates backed by powerful forces."[39] Improving democracy, argues another Cuban analyst, should "not be only, nor even principally, about multiparty systems, periodic supervised elections, or other common topics in the regional discourse about democracy, but rather about popular participation, social justice, equity, national development and other elements that are of greater importance for the construction of stable democratic regimes and the growth of societies where human rights are more fully respected."[40] Cuban scholars point to institutions like the elected Popular Power assemblies, participation in mass organizations,